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America as an Example of How a Revolution Can Have a Lasting Impact

May 2026

America- land of the free. But what does “land of the free” mean? How did the American Revolution sustain its impact for so long? It turns out that the answer to this question is a core set of beliefs that defined what freedom is, began a movement, and sustained a revolution: life, liberty, and the pursuit of happiness.

A truly lasting revolution must sustain a core set of beliefs as society evolves. The United States Congress’s system of evolving legal debate supports this core set of beliefs- life, liberty, and the pursuit of happiness- through the periodic election of representatives, the passage of laws and amendments, and the right of the common people to represent themselves in governmental processes.

First off, periodically elected representatives, such as those in the United States Congress, are beneficial to sustaining the core beliefs of a revolution through legal debate. James Madison stated that “[W]e may define a republic to be... administered by persons holding their offices during pleasure, for a limited period, or during good behavior. It is ESSENTIAL to such a government that it be derived from the great body of the society...It is SUFFICIENT for such a government that the persons administering it be appointed, either directly or indirectly, by the people.” James Madison not only believes, but defines that a republic requires periodically elected representatives. The importance of elections is to prevent government corruption and the establishment of a ruling party for more than a few years. If a corrupt or long-term ruling party emerges, such as a monarchy or a dictatorship, the quality of life for the public declines, creating the conditions for yet another revolution. If a new revolution arises from the first, it shows that the original revolution did not last, having been overturned by the newer one. That’s the beauty of electing representatives- the public will have a leader that they believe benefits them. If the public's political beliefs change, a new leader will be elected to serve the public's needs.

Furthermore, the evolving congressional process of creating and passing laws and amendments is crucial to sustaining the core beliefs of a changing and developing revolutionary society. According to the Revolutionary Republic Archives of The American Revolution Institute, “The First Congress...with Washington, satisfied the demands of many

critics of the Federal Constitution by proposing amendments defining fundamental liberties and natural and civil rights. Ratified by the states, the first ten amendments to the Federal Constitution became the federal Bill of Rights, which continues to afford fundamental protections to the rights and liberties of American citizens.” The Bill of Rights is an excellent example of how amending a revolution's core beliefs sustains its impact on society. Its creation in 1791 was due to public fears of a tyrannical government like that of the past- exactly what prevents a sustained revolution. The structure of the American legislature- a revolution itself- addressed public fear and allowed the revolution to continue with a successful impact on society. But the Bill of Rights wasn't the only example. Over the course of history, seventeen other amendments were passed, all (except the 18th amendment on prohibition) used to enhance federal, state, and individual liberties. Clearly, as the American government still exists today as it did in 1791, the twenty-seven amendments passed to enhance individual liberty and happiness sustained a revolution.

Ensuring that the common people can advocate for themselves in the law is important for sustaining revolutionary core beliefs, such as the right to free speech and petition the U.S. Congress. The Declaration of Independence's own words were: “That to secure these rights, Governments are instituted among Men, deriving their just powers from the consent of the governed... That whenever any Form of Government becomes destructive of these ends, it is the Right of the People to alter or to abolish it, and to institute new Government, laying its foundation on such principles and organizing its powers in such form, as to them shall seem most likely to effect their Safety and Happiness.” Earlier, this essay explained how representatives and laws can sustain a revolution. But these two factors require one key ingredient- public liberty. Specifically, public involvement in governance or leadership. If the revolutionary idea does not resonate with the public, it will likely be met with protests that lead to a new revolution overtaking the old one. An example of a revolution that succeeded in sustaining itself was the words in the Declaration of Independence above, which explain that any citizen has the right to participate in and change their government through free speech, petition, or protest. The Declaration of Independence's success paved the way for many successful revolutions across the world, creating freedom, innovation, and the society we live in today.

A truly lasting revolution must sustain a core set of beliefs as society evolves. A strong example of a core set of beliefs from a lasting revolution is life, liberty, and the pursuit of happiness, as used in the American Revolution. From periodically elected representatives to laws and amendments to public speech and petitions, ensuring that the government represents and serves the people is key to a lasting revolution. Today, as our society enters a revolution focused on AI, we must remember to ground it in core beliefs, backed by evolving debate, just as the American Revolution did many years ago. Without ensuring a set of core beliefs, revolutions that changed the way we live and think could not have sustained themselves. These beliefs ensure that people can live happily and openly in their daily lives.

Works Cited

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